1/Opening the Black Box of Peer Review

> There are competing narratives about what passes for being good. There are different standards of excellence, different kinds of excellence, and I'm certainly willing to entertain somebody else's standard of excellence up to a point. I'm not sure that I could articulate what that point is, but I'm pretty confident that I'd know it when I see it. You develop a little bit of a nose for it. Particularly for what's bad.
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> Sociologist

> Definitions of excellence come up every time. [My colleagues] feel perfectly comfortable saying, "I didn't think this was a terribly good book," as if what they mean by a good book is self-apparent . . . What they mean seems really sort of ephemeral or elusive.
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> English professor

> I felt like we were sitting on the top of a pyramid where people had been selected out at various stages of their lives and we were getting people who had demonstrated a fair amount of confidence and were sorting between kind of B, B+, and A scholars, and we all thought we were A's.
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> Political scientist

"Excellence" is the holy grail of academic life. Scholars strive to produce research that will influence the direction of their field. Universities compete to improve their relative rankings. Students seek inspiring mentors. But if excellence is ubiquitously evoked, there is little cross-disciplinary consensus about what it means and how it is achieved, especially in the world of research. "The cream of the crop" in an English or anthropology department has little in common with "the best and the brightest" in an economics department. This disparity does not occur because the academic enterprise is bankrupt or meaningless. It happens because disciplines shine under varying lights and because their members define quality in various ways. Moreover, criteria for assessing quality or excellence can be differently weighted and are the object of intense conflicts. Making sense of standards and the meanings given to them is the object of this book.

The Latin word *academia* refers to a community dedicated to higher learning. At its center are colleagues who are defined as "peers" or "equals," and whose opinions shape shared definitions of quality. In the omnipresent academic evaluation system known as peer review, peers pass judgment, usually confidentially, on the quality of the work of other community members. Thus they determine the allocation of scarce resources, whether these be prestige and honors, fellowships and grants to support research, tenured positions that provide identifiable status and job security, or access to high-status publications. Peers monitor the flow of people and ideas through the various gates of the academic community. But because academia is not democratic, some peers are given more of a voice than others and serve as gatekeepers more often than others. Still, different people guard different gates, so gatekeepers are themselves subject to evaluation at various times.[1]

Peer review is secretive. Only those present in the deliberative chambers know exactly what happens there. In this book I report what I have learned about this peculiar world. I studied humanists and social scientists serving on multidisciplinary panels that had been charged with distributing prestigious fellowships and grants in support of scholarly research. I conducted in-depth interviews with these experts and also observed their deliberations. During their face-to-face discussions, panelists make their criteria of evaluation explicit to one another as they weigh the merits of individual proposals and try to align their own standards with those of the applicants' disciplines. Hence, grant review panels offer an ideal setting for observing competing academic definitions of excellence. That peer evaluation consumes what for many academics seems like an ever-growing portion of their time is an additional reason to give it a close look.

Academic excellence is produced and defined in a multitude of sites and by an array of actors. It may look different when observed through the lenses of editorial peer review, books that are read by generations of students, current articles published by top journals, elections at national academies, or appointments at elite institutions. American higher education also has in place elaborate processes for hiring, promoting, and firing academics. Systematically examining parts of this machinery is an essential step in assessing the extent to which this system is harmonized by a shared evaluative culture.

Evaluations of fellowship programs typically seek answers to such questions as: Are these programs successful in identifying talent? Do awardees live up to their promise? The tacit assumption is that these programs give awards to talented people with the hope that the fellowship will help them become "all they can be."[2] Examining how the worth of academic work is ascertained is a more counterintuitive, but I think ultimately more intriguing, undertaking. Rather than focusing on the trajectory of the brilliant individual or the outstanding oeuvre, I approach the riddle of success by analyzing the context of evaluation—including which standards define and constrain what we see as excellent.[3]

By way of introduction, I pose and answer the same kinds of questions that are typically asked in peer review of completed or proposed research proposals.

What do you study? I study evaluative cultures.[4] This broad term includes many components: cultural scripts that panelists employ when discussing their assessments (is the process meritocratic?);[5] the meaning that panelists give to criteria (for instance, how do you recognize originality?); the weight they attribute to various standards (for example, “quality” versus “diversity”); and how they understand excellence. Do they believe excellence has an objective reality? If so, where is it located—in the proposal (as economists generally believe) or in the eye of the beholder (as English scholars claim)?

Evaluative cultures also include how reviewers conceive of the relationship between evaluation and power dynamics, their ability to judge and reach consensus, and their views on disciplinary boundaries and the worth and fate of various academic fields. Finally, evaluative cultures include whether panelists think that subjectivity has a corrupting influence on evaluation (the caricatured view of those in the harder social sciences) or is intrinsic to appreciation and connoisseurship (the view of those in the humanities and more interpretive social sciences).[6]

I study shared standards and evaluative disciplinary cultures in six disciplines. Each presents its own characteristics and challenges. In philosophy, members claim a monopoly on the assessment of their disciplinary knowledge. In history, a relatively strong consensus is based on a shared sense of craftsmanship. Anthropologists are preoccupied with defining and maintaining the boundaries of their discipline. English literary scholars experience their field as undergoing a “legitimation crisis,” while political scientists experience theirs as divided. In contrast, economists view their own field as consensual and unified by mathematical formalism.

Whom do you study? I study panelists, who are, in principle, highly regarded experts known for their good "people skills" and sound judgments. They have agreed to serve on grant peer review panels for a host of reasons having to do with influence, curiosity, or pleasure. Some say that they are "tremendously delighted" to spend a day or two witnessing brilliant minds at work. Others serve on panels to participate in a context where they can be appreciated, that is, where they can sustain—and ideally, enhance—their identities as highly respected experts whose opinions matter.

Why study peer review? As I write, debates are raging about the relative significance of excellence and diversity in the allocation of resources in American higher education. Are we sacrificing one for the other? Analyzing the wider culture of evaluation helps us understand their relationship. For all but the top winners, decisions to fund are based generally on a delicate combination of considerations that involve both excellence and diversity. Often panelists compete to determine which of several different types of diversity will push an A− or B+ proposal above the line for funding—and very few proposals are pure As. Evaluators are most concerned with disciplinary and institutional diversity, that is, ensuring that funding not be restricted to scholars in only a few fields or at top universities. A few are also concerned with ethnoracial diversity, gender, and geographic diversity. Contra popular debates, in the real world of grant peer review, excellence and diversity are not alternatives; they are additive considerations. The analysis I provide makes clear that having a degree from say, a Midwestern state university, instead of from Yale, is not weighed in a predictable direction in decision-making processes. Similarly, while being a woman or person of color may help in some contexts, it hurts in others.[7]

What kind of approach do you take? I think that as social actors seeking to make sense of our everyday lives, we are guided primarily by pragmatic, problem-solving sorts of concerns. Accordingly, my analysis shows that panelists adopt a pragmatic approach to evaluation. They need to reach a consensus about a certain number of proposals by a predetermined time, a practical concern that shapes what they do as well as how they understand the fairness of the process. They develop a sense of shared criteria as the deliberations proceed, and they self-correct in dialogue with one another, as they "learn by monitoring."[8] Moreover, while the language of excellence presumes a neat hierarchy from the best to the worst proposals, panelists adopt a nonlinear approach to evaluation. They compare proposals according to shared characteristics as varied as topic, method, geographical area, or even alphabetical order. Evaluators are often aware of the inconsistencies imposed by the conditions under which they carry out their task.

What do you find? The actions of panelists are constrained by the mechanics of peer review, with specific procedures (concerning the rules of deliberation, for instance) guiding their work. Their evaluations are shaped by their respective disciplinary evaluative cultures, and by formal criteria (such as originality, significance, feasibility) provided by the funding competition. Reviewers also bring into the mix diversity considerations and more evanescent criteria—elegance, for example. Yet despite this wide array of disciplinary differences, they develop together shared rules of deliberation that facilitate agreement. These rules include respecting the sovereignty of other disciplines and deferring to the expertise of colleagues. They entail bracketing self-interest, idiosyncratic taste, and disciplinary prejudices, and promoting methodological pluralism and cognitive contextualization (that is, the use of discipline-relevant criteria of evaluation). Respect for these rules leads panelists to believe that the peer review process works, because panelists judge each other's standards and behavior just as much as they judge proposals.[9]

Peer review has come under a considerable amount of criticism and scrutiny.[10] Various means—ranging from double-blind reviewing to training and rating—are available to enforce consistency, ensure replicability and stability, and reduce ambiguity. Grant peer review still favors the face-to-face meeting, unlike editorial peer review, where evaluators assess papers and book manuscripts in isolation and make recommendations, usually in writing, to physically distant editors.[11] Debating plays a crucial role in creating trust: fair decisions emerge from a dialogue among various types of experts, a dialogue that leaves room for discretion, uncertainty, and the weighing of a range of factors and competing forms of excellence. It also leaves room for flexibility and for groups to develop their own shared sense of what defines excellence—that is, their own group style, including speech norms and implicit group boundaries.[12] Personal authority does not necessarily corrupt the process: it is constructed by the group as a medium for expertise and as a ground for trust in the quality of decisions made.[13] These are some of the reasons that deliberation is viewed as a better tool for detecting quality than quantitative techniques such as citation counts.

It may be possible to determine the fairness of particular decisions, but it is impossible to reach a definite, evidence-based conclusion concerning the system as a whole. Participants' faith in the system, however, has a tremendous influence on how well it works. Belief in the legitimacy of the system affects individual actions (for instance, the countless hours spent reading applications) as well as evaluators' understanding of what is acceptable behavior (such as whether and how to signal the disregard of personal interest in making awards). Thus embracing the system has important, positive effects on the panelists' behavior.[14]

What is the significance of the study? The literature on peer review has focused almost exclusively on the cognitive dimensions of evaluation and conceives of extracognitive dimensions as corrupting influences.[15] In my view, however, evaluation is a process that is deeply emotional and interactional. It is culturally embedded and influenced by the "social identity" of panelists—that is, their self-concept and how others define them.[16] Reviewers' very real desire to have their opinion respected by their colleagues also plays an important role in deliberations. Consensus formation is fragile and requires considerable emotional work.[17] Maintaining collegiality is crucial. It is also challenging, because the distinctive features of American higher education (spatial dispersion, social and geographic mobility, the sheer size of the field, and so on) increase uncertainty in interaction.

Is higher education really meritocratic? Are academics a self-reproducing elite?[18] These and similar questions are closely tied to issues of biases in evaluation and the trustworthiness of evaluators. Expertise and connoisseurship (or ability to discriminate) can easily slide into homophily (an appreciation for work that most resembles one's own). Evaluators, who are generally senior and established academics, often define excellence as "what speaks most to me," which is often akin to "what is most like me," with the result that the "haves"—anyone associated with a top institution or a dominant paradigm—may receive a disproportionate amount of resources.[19] The tendency toward homophily may explain the perceived conservative bias in funding: it is widely believed that particularly creative and original projects must clear higher hurdles in order to get funded.[20] It would also help explain the Matthew effect (that is, the tendency for resources to go to those who already have them).[21]

But I find a more complex pattern. Evaluators often favor their own type of research while also being firmly committed to rewarding the strongest proposal. Panelists are necessarily situated in particular cognitive and social networks. They all have students, colleagues, and friends with whom they share what is often a fairly small cognitive universe (subfield or subspecialty) and they are frequently asked to adjudicate the work of individuals with whom they have only a few degrees of separation. While their understanding of what defines excellence is contingent on the cultural environment in which they are located, when scholars are called on to act as judges, they are encouraged to step out of their normal milieus to assess quality as defined through absolute and decontextualized standards. Indeed, their own identity is often tied to their self-concept as experts who are able to stand above their personal interest. Thus, evaluators experience contradictory pushes and pulls as they strive to adjudicate quality.[22]

What are the epistemological implications of the study? Much like the nineteenth-century French social scientist Auguste Comte, some contemporary academics believe that disciplines can be neatly ranked in a single hierarchy (although few follow Comte's lead and place sociology at the top). The matrix of choice is disciplinary "maturity," as measured by consensus and growth, but some also favor scientificity and objectivity.[23] Others firmly believe that the hard sciences should not serve as the aspirational model, especially given that there are multiple models for doing science, including many that do not fit the prevailing archetypical representations.[24] In the social sciences and the humanities, the more scientific and more interpretive disciplines favor very different forms of originality (with a focus on new approaches, new data, or new methods).[25] From a normative standpoint, one leitmotif of my analysis is that disciplines shine under different lights, are good at different things, and are best located on different matrixes of evaluation, precisely because their objects and concerns differ so dramatically. For instance, in some fields knowledge is best approached through questions having to do with "how much"; other fields raise "how" and "why" questions that require the use of alternative approaches, interpretive tools, methods, and data-gathering techniques. These fundamental differences imply that excellence and epistemological diversity are not dichotomous choices. Instead, diversity supports the existence of various types of excellence.

Is the study timely? At the start of the twenty-first century, as I was conducting interviews, market forces had come to favor increasingly the more professional and preprofessional fields, as well as research tied to profit-making.[26] Moreover, the technology of peer review has long been embedded in a vast academic culture that values science. In the public sphere, the social sciences continue to be the terrain for a tug-of-war between neoliberal market explanations for societal or human behavior and other, more institutional and cultural accounts.[27] By illuminating how pluralism factors into evaluation processes, I hope to help maintain a sense of multiple possibilities.

Many factors in American higher education work against disciplinary and epistemological pluralism. Going against the tide in any endeavor is often difficult; it may be even more so in scholarly research, because independence of thinking is not easily maintained in systems where mentorship and sponsored mobility loom large.[28] Innovators are often penalized if they go too far in breaking boundaries, even if by doing so they redefine conventions and pave the way for future changes.[29] In the context of academic evaluation, there does not appear to be a clear alternative to the system of peer review.[30] Moreover, there seems to be agreement among the study's respondents that despite its flaws, overall this system "works." Whether academics who are never asked to evaluate proposals and those who never apply for funds share this opinion remains an open question.

Despite all the uncertainties about academic judgment, I aim to combat intellectual cynicism. Post-structuralism has led large numbers of academics to view notions of truth and reality as highly arbitrary. Yet many still care deeply about "excellence" and remain strongly committed to identifying and rewarding it, though they may not define it the same way.

I also aim to provide a deeper understanding, grounded in solid research, of the competing criteria of evaluation at stake in academic debates. Empirically grounded disciplines, such as political science and sociology, have experienced important conflicts regarding the place of formal theory and quantitative research techniques in disciplinary standards of excellence. In political science, strong tensions have accompanied the growing influence of rational choice theory.[31] In the 1990s, disagreements surrounding the American Sociological Association's choice of an editor for its flagship journal, the *American Sociological Review,* have generated lively discussion about the place of qualitative and quantitative research in the field.[32] In both disciplines, diversity and academic distinction are often perceived as mutually exclusive criteria for selecting leaders of professional associations. My analysis may help move the discussion beyond polemics.

Also, the book examines at the micro level the coproduction of the social and the academic.[33] Since the late 1960s, and based on their understanding of the standards of evaluation used in government organizations, sociologists seeking support from government funding agencies began to incorporate more quantitative techniques in part as a way of legitimizing their work as "scientific."[34] At the same time, government organizations became increasingly dependent on social science knowledge (for example, census information, data pertaining to school achievement, unemployment rates among various groups) as a foundation for social engineering. Thus, knowledge networks and networks of resource distribution have grown in parallel—and this alignment has sustained disciplinary hierarchies. The more a researcher depends on external sources of funding, the less autonomous he or she is when choosing a problem to study.[35] Standards of evaluation that are salient, or that researchers perceive as salient, shape the kind of work that they undertake. These standards also affect the likelihood that scholars will obtain funding and gain status, since receiving fellowships is central to the acquisition of academic prestige.[36] Thus are put in place the conditions for the broader hierarchy of the academic world.

Most of all, I want to open the black box of peer review and make the process of evaluation more transparent, especially for younger academics looking in from the outside.[37] I also want to make the older, established scholars—the gatekeepers—think hard and think again about the limits of what they are doing, particularly when they define "what is exciting" as "what most looks like me (or my work)." Providing a wider perspective may help broaden the disciplinary tunnel vision that afflicts so many. A greater understanding of the differences and similarities across disciplinary cultures may lead academics toward a greater tolerance of, or even an appreciation for, fields outside their own. And coming to see the process as moved by customary rules may help all evaluators view the system in a different and broader perspective as well as develop greater humility and a more realistic sense of their cosmic significance, or lack thereof, in the great contest over excellence.

I now turn to the details of how the research was conducted and to the minutiae of disciplinary positioning. Readers who are not interested in these topics should move directly to Chapter 2, which describes how panels work.

The scholars I talked with served on funding panels that evaluate grant or fellowship proposals submitted by faculty members and graduate students. I interviewed scholars involved in five different national funding competitions and twelve different panels over a two-year period around the turn of the century (for details, see the

Appendix).[38] The individual funding organizations (and the specific competitions studied) are the American Council for Learned Societies (ACLS—the Humanities Fellowship program); a Society of Fellows (an international competition for a residential fellowship sponsored by a top research university); the Social Science Research Council (SSRC—the International Dissertation Field Research program); the Woodrow Wilson National Fellowship Foundation (WWNFF—the Women's Studies program); and an anonymous foundation in the social sciences. In each of these cases, I spoke with panelists, panel chairs, and program officers individually for approximately two hours each. These eighty-one interviews, which include fifteen interviews with program officers and panel chairs, were conducted in absolute confidentiality and occurred within a few hours or a few days of the conclusion of their panel deliberations.

The object of the interviews was to learn about the arguments that panelists had made for and against specific proposals, their views about the outcomes of the competition, and the thinking behind the ranking of proposals both prior to and after the panel meeting. I had both sets of rankings in hand during each interview. Other questions concerned how panelists interpreted the process of selection and its outcome; how they compared their evaluations to those of other panelists; how they recognized excellence in their graduate students, among their colleagues, and in their own work; whether they believed in academic excellence and why; and whether they thought that, in my words, "the cream rises to the top." I also asked interviewees to cite examples of work that they especially appreciated and to explain why they so highly valued this work. My aim here was to locate respondents' framing of excellence within their broader conception of their own scholarly selves.[39] I read a large sample of the finalist proposals before conducting the interviews, to gain background information and prepare targeted questions. In three cases where I was able to observe deliberations firsthand, I used my field notes to probe panelists during the post-deliberation interviews.[40] As a whole, the interviews generated not only information on panelists' understanding of how they assess excellence, but also ethnographic information on the evaluation process itself—from both an organizational and a cultural perspective. I collected several individual accounts about the deliberation and ranking processes to gain complementary and thus more accurate understandings of the types of arguments made by various scholars about a range of proposals.

Most of the literature on peer review tends to neglect the meaning given to criteria of evaluation. To rectify this oversight, I took a different approach. I used an open-ended and inductive interview technique to ask panelists to draw boundaries between what they consider the best and the worst proposals. This made it possible to identify the criteria underpinning their evaluations and to reconstruct the classification system they used. I had found this method effective in my earlier studies of conceptions of worth among middle-class and working-class people. It was particularly fruitful for the study of topics as sensitive as class resentment, racism, and xenophobia in France and the United States.[41] People are less likely to censor themselves when drawing boundaries because they are often unaware that they draw boundaries as they describe the world. Focusing on boundaries in this study was also useful because what the reviewer takes for granted may well drive his boundary work more than his or her explicitly stated beliefs.[42]

All the panels I studied were composed of scholars from different disciplines, but the competitions they judged were open to both disciplinary and interdisciplinary proposals. Panel members were from the social sciences and the humanities, fields often portrayed as less consensual than the pure and applied sciences. The interviewees represent a wide range of disciplines. Some hailed from economics, philosophy, or sociology. Others came from disciplines that have undergone profound epistemological changes over recent decades—such as anthropology, English, history, and political science. And some came from smaller disciplines, such as musicology, geography, and art history. I interviewed scholars about their own disciplines and disciplinary standards as well as about their perceptions of the similarities and differences among fields. Thus my analysis of each discipline draws on multiple accounts. Responses ranged from the highly developed and coherent to the off-the-cuff, unreflective, and inchoate. Participants' frank appraisals of their own and others' fields offer a unique window into what academics—and academia—are all about. My analysis uncovers a world that is understood only partially and generally imperfectly, even by most members of the academic community, let alone the general public.

Grants and fellowships are becoming increasingly important as academic signals of excellence, especially because the proliferation of journals has made the number of publications of academics a less reliable measure of their status.[43] Of the two, fellowships are considered a better measure of excellence than are grants, because across all the social sciences and the humanities, academics are eager to receive fellowships that will support their leaves and allow them to pursue their research. Grants, though valuable and customary in the social sciences where research often requires costly data collection, are less important in the humanities. Prestigious fellowships tell recipients about the quality of their work relative to that of others, and in so doing, they increase motivation and self-confidence.[44] They also provide a public enhancement of status, because a panel of experts has agreed that one's work is superior to that of many other candidates.[45] Indeed, in a recent year, the ratio of awards to applicants was 1:12 for the WWNFF and ACLS competitions; 1:16 for the SSRC competition; and 1:200 for the Society of Fellows. Perhaps less significantly, these competitions also provide material support, which ranges from $3,000 (in the case of WWNFF dissertation grants) to $50,000 (in the case of ACLS fellowships to full professors). These funding panels serve an important role for evaluators as well, providing an instantiation of the esteem that colleagues have for their expertise. In the academic world, being invited to sit on a panel for a prestigious competition can carry a reward that is the symbolic equivalent of the annual bonus bestowed on the senior vice-president of a well-known corporation. The value that evaluators accord such invitations varies greatly with their own position in the academic hierarchy and their degree of seniority, however.

How do I figure in the story? I have a long-standing research interest in the sociology of knowledge and have established expertise in this field.[46] Equally important, I am simultaneously an insider and an outsider to the system I describe.[47] As I note in the acknowledgments, my research was supported by several prestigious grants and fellowship programs, funding sources of the very sort that I analyze in this book. I am also a tenured Harvard professor. Moreover, I have served on a number of funding panels of the same type that I studied (but not the same competitions). These facts alone might seem to make me the consummate insider, a gatekeeper par excellence. And indeed, insiderhood has influenced my analysis in myriad ways—facilitating access to the rather secretive milieus of funding organizations, for instance, and helping me understand these milieus, even as I deliberately made the familiar strange.

Despite my status as an "insider," I am also in some ways an outsider, first because I have had a very unusual professional trajectory. I was socialized in the American higher education system only after having completed my graduate work at the University of Paris. My sense of that distance has always been compounded by my being an ethnographer, a role that provides—indeed, requires—distance if the researcher is to have any hope of deciphering how the natives think, what makes them tick. Moreover, I did not think, socialize, or work in English before coming to the United States at the age of twentyfive. My French-inflected speech cadence and accent continually remind those around me of my otherness.

I also conceive of myself as an outsider because I am a woman, which along with being an immigrant may put me at the margin to some extent, and may help explain why I am not enamored of "insiderism." And it is not irrelevant that most of my past scholarship has concerned racial and class boundaries and social exclusion. This background informs the book's argument that a belief in the relative fairness and openness of the peer review system is crucial to the vitality of American higher education. That belief invites and encourages outsiders to take a gamble and participate in these scholarly competitions, even if they think that the system is only partly meritocratic. Finally, at the center of this book is my own self, and the self-understanding of academics who labor, at least sometimes, to maintain a meaningful life.

The pragmatic approach to evaluation I advocate draws on paradigms from sociology—ethnomethodology and symbolic interactionism (associated with the works of Irving Garfinkel and Erving Goffman, respectively)—that focus attention on the conditions of the collective accomplishment of social life and the social order. These theories have helped me make sense of how social actors (panelists, principally, but also program officers, applicants, and the academic community at large) collaborate to create the conditions necessary for the allocation of awards.[48] My analysis is also informed by the American and European traditions of pragmatic and cultural analysis, because these focus attention on the competing webs of meanings that human beings spin to make sense of their everyday activities—including how people think conflicts should be expressed and conducted, so as not to betray the notion of meritocracy and fair play.[49] Moreover, I build on insights derived from science studies concerning expertise, credibility, the stabilization of facts, and the closure of controversies. Here, studies by Bruno Latour and Steven

Woolgar on circles of credibility and Harry Collins on claims of expertise have been especially helpful.[50] Thus my approach can be contrasted with the views of Robert K. Merton, Richard Whitley, and Pierre Bourdieu, all of whom have addressed academic evaluation.

Most of the research on the topic of how quality is assessed has focused on issues raised by Robert K. Merton's influential work in the sociology of knowledge: consensus in science, issues of universalistic and particularistic evaluation relating to the ethos of science, and the variously construed Matthew and halo effects of reputation and prestige (with halo effect referring to the gain of prestige by association).[51] Researchers working on this topic have addressed whether judgments about "irrelevant," particularistic characteristics, like the age and reputation of the author, affect (or corrupt) the evaluation of his or her work. More recent studies are also concerned with the fairness of the peer review process.[52] Although these studies have made important contributions, their framing of the question implies that a unified process of evaluation can be put in place once particularistic considerations have been eliminated. They tend to overlook that evaluation is not based on stable comparables, and that various competing criteria with multiple meanings are used to assess academic work. These criteria include stylistic virtuosity and the display of cultural capital, empirical soundness, and methodological sophistication.

I build on prior studies by beginning exactly where they leave off: I conduct a detailed examination of neglected aspects of the evaluation process. I analyze situations where the meanings of norms as defined by Merton (for example, about universalism) are created. Using methods similar to those in an earlier study, I undertake a content analysis of grant proposal evaluations, but unlike previous work, I am concerned with disciplinary differences and with criteria of evaluation.[53] For instance, whereas past research found that the significance of a project has a strong influence on funding, I probe what reviewers and panel members from different disciplines mean by "significance." And whereas much of the available literature is concerned with fairness, I examine what is perceived as fair and what panelists do to enact and sustain fairness.[54] I find that between proposals the criteria for comparison and evaluation are continually changing, as different proposals are regrouped based on different principles and compared. Path dependency best explains the definition of the comparables—think of real-estate agents using different comparables across neighborhoods over time, or the "gut feelings" we all experience while making comparative and contextual judgments, feelings that cognitive psychologists inform us are shaped by initial "priming" experiences.[55] Evaluation is by necessity a fragile and uncertain endeavor and one that requires "emotion work" if it is to proceed smoothly. Moreover, the panelists' sense of self and relative positioning cannot be dissociated from the process; it is intrinsic to it. Thus, in contrast to Merton and his associates, I suggest that these extra-cognitive elements do not corrupt the process: evaluation is impossible without them.[56]

Sociologists Richard Whitley and Pierre Bourdieu are among the few scholars who provide systematic bases on which to ground a comparison of disciplines.[57] Whitley focuses on dependency and task uncertainty to predict power relations within fields. He suggests that the greater the need to pool resources within a given discipline or subdiscipline, the greater the competition between scientists over making a reputation and gaining control over material resources. He predicts that in a field characterized by what he calls low functional dependence and high strategic dependence (such as English literature), scholarly contributions will be judged in "relatively diffuse and tacit ways with considerable reliance upon personal contacts and knowledge."[58] Similarly, in *Homo Academicus,* Bourdieu analyzes scientists as people engaged in a struggle to impose as legitimate their vision of the world—and their definition of high-quality scholarly work. Whitley and Bourdieu tell us that scholars compete to define excellence, and then point to the coexistence of alternative criteria of evaluation. Neither author, however, analyzes these criteria inductively. Even in his early work with Monique de St. Martin, where Bourdieu pointed to categories of judgment applied to academic work (such as its excellence or "brilliance"), he did not analyze the meaning of criteria used to place a proposal in a given category.[59] In contrast, this book provides a detailed empirical analysis of the meaning of criteria on which scholars rely to distinguish "excellent" and "promising" research from less stellar work.

My approach differs from Bourdieu's in other ways. Bourdieu argues that the judgments of scholars reflect and serve their position in their academic field, even if they naturalize these judgments and legitimize them in universalistic terms. While he examines the social and economic filtering that lie behind interests, he does not consider whether and how defending excellence is central to the self-concept of many academics and how aspects of disinterestedness, such as pleasure, can be more than a self-serving illusion.[60] In contrast, I factor into the analysis academics' sense of self and their emotions. While Bourdieu suggests that in the competition for distinction, conflicts are strongest among those occupying similar positions in fields, my interviews suggest that actors are motivated by not only the opportunity to maximize their position, but also their pragmatic involvement in collective problem solving.[61] Thus, contra Merton, Bourdieu, and Whitley, I oppose a view of peer review that is driven only or primarily by a competitive logic (or the market) and suggest in addition that peer review is an interactional and an emotional undertaking. In short, building on Goffman, my analysis suggests the importance of considering the self and emotions—in particular pleasure, saving face, and maintaining one's self-concept—as part of the investment that academics make in scholarly evaluation.[62] Contra Whitley, I also argue that homophilic judgments are pervasive across the social sciences and the humanities. How people approach evaluation as problem solving, how they develop evaluative practices and articulate their beliefs, and how they represent the process to themselves are crucial to my analysis.

I also emphasize, in the pragmatist tradition, a pluralism of perspectives and communication styles. New French pragmatism focuses on coordinated action in situations of evaluation.[63] I share with this approach a concern for analyzing the combination of standards of evaluation used and the ways in which panelists make arguments while promoting particular conceptions of fairness. But I do not use predefined logics of justification. Instead, my approach to understanding evaluation criteria is more inductive. It owes much to John Dewey, and to others who are concerned with how trust emerges around problem solving, dialogue, and learning.[64] I am also more concerned with the organizational logic that leads people to "satisfice" (to make "good enough," as opposed to optimal, decisions) given the constraints within which decisions have to be made. Thus my approach is a fairly radical departure from the canonical literature on peer review, which remains concerned primarily with cognitive aspects of evaluation.